Society of Natural Capital Accounting
SoNCA

Proposing a seminar or a working group

A guide for proposers, version 20 October 2026

The Society exists to: (1) raise awareness and understanding of natural capital accounting; (2) develop professional pathways; and (3) provide a forum for exchanging ideas and experience.

Anyone may propose a seminar, whether or not they are a member of the Society, and speakers need not be members. The lead, co-lead and core members of a working group must be members, and a group may invite speakers who are not members. Non-members may take part in seminars, but not in working groups.

This guide explains what you can propose, what the committee looks for, and what happens after you send a form proposing a seminar or working group. The Society's committee manages the activity of the Society. Both forms can be completed without this guide. This document provides background information, describes the differences between seminar and working group proposals, and what happens after you submit a form proposing a seminar or working group.

What you can propose

A seminar has the Society's name and is built around a question or questions relevant to the Society's aims. It is a single online session of about an hour, open to members and non-members alike, with more than one speaker and space for discussion. It is the ordinary way to bring something to the Society, and others into it. The proposal process ensures each proposal is considered fairly and against the Society's aims. The threshold for acceptance is deliberately modest. Please use Form SEM-1.

A working group has the Society's name and is built around issues and questions relevant to the Society's aims. It operates outside the seminar programme, runs for 12 months, may be renewed, and works largely independently of the committee. It must have a lead, a co-lead and at least one further core member, a work programme, deliverables including at least one seminar for the Society each year, and a quarterly report to the committee. Core members are the people who found and run the group; it is not an office in the Society. All members of a working group must be members of the Society, and every group is open to all members. The threshold is higher for working groups than for seminars. Please use **Form WG-1**.

The usual route to a group is through a seminar. Run a session, put the question or questions to the Society, and finish with an open invitation to form a group. This is how we expect most groups to start, and it means people form the group by coming forward rather than being chosen in advance.

A chapter is a geographic body that represents the Society in a region. Chapters raise questions of delegation and legal identity that the Society has not yet settled, so they are not being considered in the foundation year. Regional expressions of interest are very welcome, by email to inquiries@naturalcapitalaccounting.org. There is no form for this.

Build seminars around a question or questions

Seminars are structured around a question or questions, with context provided as needed. More than one speaker is needed, and there must be space for discussion and questions, perhaps by a panel, and with the audience. The Society is convening a professional debate. A seminar may be based on a particular piece of work, but it should focus on the lessons and questions the work raises, not the results.

> *Each seminar should do three things: (1) let members see what is happening; (2) put a question the profession needs to answer, and discuss it; and (3) bring people in from outside the Society.*

What the committee looks for

Seven criteria are applied to every proposal, so that people the committee does not know are assessed on the same terms as people it does.

1. **Aims.** It serves at least one of the Society's three aims, and the proposal says which.
2. **Practice.** It addresses something practitioners actually do, rather than something an existing body already convenes.
3. **Question.** It is built around a question, with more than one answer possible.
4. **Balance.** The lead and the co-lead between them bring more than one country, sector or discipline, and at least one has substantial experience of the System of Environmental-Economic Accounting (SEEA). Where a proposal works to a different standard, it says which, and how it is similar to or different from the SEEA. Substantial experience of the SEEA is shown by at least one of: compiling SEEA accounts; contributing to SEEA standards, guidance or training; publishing work applying the SEEA; or teaching it.
5. **Deliverable.** There is a product and a date, however modest: a recording, a note, a comparison, worked examples, a submission.
6. **Independence.** Interests are declared, and the proposal does not put the Society in the position of endorsing a standard, a method or a product, or hosting the launch of one.
7. **Capacity.** Someone other than the committee will do the work.

What happens after you send the form

1. **Acknowledgement.** Within a few days. An acknowledgement is not a decision.
2. **Committee.** Proposals are considered at the next committee meeting. A seminar may be approved between meetings where the date requires it; a working group may not. The committee approves, approves with changes, or declines with reasons, in writing.
3. **Publication.** An approved seminar goes on the website three to four weeks ahead, with its question, its speakers, the date and the declarations of interest. We ask you for 600 to 800 words on the topic and may edit it for style.
4. **The session.** A committee member introduces it and runs the questions. You present and lead the substance. It is recorded and published.
5. **Afterwards.** Seminar leads send a short report and a paragraph for the website within a fortnight. Working groups report each quarter, present to members at least once a year, and are reviewed at twelve months, when the group closes unless the committee renews it.

Seminars are held about every two months, with additional sessions where something warrants one, and the hour rotates so that the Americas, Europe and Africa, and the Asia-Pacific each get a workable time.

Declaring an interest

Every seminar and working group carries declarations of interest, published alongside it. For a seminar, each speaker, including the lead and the co-lead, declares for themselves on Form SPK-1 at least one week before the seminar, and the proposal covers the seminar as a whole. For a working group, the core members declare on Form WG-1. Declare any role in a standard setting body, a consultancy, a certification or credit scheme, or an organisation with a commercial interest in the subject, and any funding or client relationship that bears on it. Responsibility for declarations rests with the people who make them. The Society does not verify declarations, does not represent them as true, and takes on no duty to investigate. An interest is not a barrier — most people worth hearing have one. An undeclared interest is a different matter.

What the Society will not do

- It is not a standard setter. Groups may compare, explain, test and comment on standards, and may make submissions where the committee agrees. The Society does not issue standards or endorse one approach over another.
- It is not a lobby for any sector or interest, and no seminar or group speaks for the Society in public unless the committee has agreed to the text. People take part in the Society's seminars and working groups in their individual professional capacity, and the Society does not endorse what is said in them.
- It does not lend its platform to the launch or consultation of a standard under development unless the committee has agreed and a competing approach is in the room.

- It does not classify its members by whom they work for. Natural capital accounting is one discipline, and the programme is organised by questions, not by sector.
- It does not create sectoral branches. Groups form around questions, and the only geographic body is a chapter.

Practical points

- Seminars are open to anyone. Working groups are for members.
- Write in note form; the committee is assessing the idea and the people, not the prose. Keep to the length suggested against each question, and do not paste in passages from other documents.
- If you have an idea but not a co-lead, send it anyway and say so. We can help you find the second person, and it is a poor reason to pass on a good proposal.

Forms and questions: inquiries@naturalcapitalaccounting.org